Each Time That We Give A Little Bit (It Comes Back To Haunt Us)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53250907.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Part 3 of Making Light Hope Proud (WiPs I Won't Continue)

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by Nny11

Summary

Catra is a confused ghost that Scorpia and Entrapta are trying to help pass on to the other side, but first they need to find the woman she loved.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The Scene/Chapter

Chapter Summary

> Here's the completed first chapter for the fic, next chapter is the plan and a bonus end scene!

Scorpia leaned over and knocked three times on the old wood chest she was sitting next to. “Hello! I’m Scorpia!”

Entrapta quickly took her cue and knocked on the nearest item three times as well, despite feeling strongly that it didn’t matter to spirits, she did it because it mattered to her friend. “And I’m Entrapta! Behind the camera is Emily, I built her myself, ISN’T SHE GREAT!?”

There was a long wait where Scorpia just smiled softly at her before continuing, “If there’s anyone here tonight, we’d love to chat!”

Entrapta was already sweeping her K-II around the room again, having taken a baseline reading and mentally mapped where various wires and electronics were. This was finicky and inaccurate at best but sometimes it really did help, especially with the protective blockers she’d installed onto it. While Scorpia seemed content to wait, Entrapta decided to let them know why the three of them were here. Spirits were more likely to interact if they knew the *whys* after all. It was one of her favorite things about them! “Full disclosure, we are not ghost hunters or paranormal investigators. We find people who are trapped, possessing, or haunting items and then help them do things, such as return the item to its original home or reconnect spirits to loved ones. Etcetera, etcetera.”

“But, even if you’re tied to or content with this location, or don’t care to go elsewhere, we’re happy to talk. Just please be respectful if there’s someone else there who wants to utilize our services.”

“K-II spike,” Entrapta noted for the rolling EVP recorder. “Was that someone who wants to talk? You can touch this again, or the REM pod on the floor, it’s the one under the faraday cage and it beeps when you get close. We’ve also got a spirit box of sorts with us if you have the energy to speak directly.”

There was a crackle and pop and a strange electronic sound before the spirit box activated. *This talks?*

“This talks,” Scorpia dutifully repeated to make sure she understood the message. “Yes it does! Hi. What’s your name?”

There was static, something electronic swelling and retreating, and a whisper. *Not important.*

“Not important? I don’t believe that for a second,” Scorpia smiled around the room, not sure where their newest contact was. “Everyone’s important and that includes you.”

It was truly unfortunate how many people thought they weren’t important enough to be remembered, although it was refreshing that one of them was just willing to admit that out loud. She had her own theory that it could be why some people remained trapped as spirits but so far it was anecdotal at best. Entrapta returned to her sweep, keeping an ear out for any knocks. If they could make contact so strong and so fast, this one could really say anything to them in many different formats.

Scorpia frowned at the slightly unhinged laughter crackling through the box before continuing on as earnestly as ever, “Hey. I mean it, you’re important to me. I wouldn’t be here talking to you if I didn’t care about you.”

Idiot.

“Ya know, I have been called an idiot before, but that’s mean of you. Caring about people isn’t stupid, and if someone told you that then *they’re* the idiot. ...C’mon buddy, give us a name. Pronouns. Anything? It’s awkward when I don’t know what to call you, and I don’t want to misgender you either.” Scorpia’s eyes

went wide, and Entrapta noted that the hair on her arms was standing straight up now.

Dang it, that marked the 53rd instance that Scorpia's connection to the spirit world triggered and Entrapta had not been sensitive enough to feel it. She tried not to pout that her last round of trying to thin the veil out for herself had failed again. Ah well, she'd try it again next time and someday she would have a somatic reaction! Probably!

Woman.

"You're a woman? Hey, us too! Look at the three of us being all simpatico!" Scorpia grinned as another laugh came through, this time more squeaky. Entrapta smiled, she liked cute laughs! "I use she/her, Entrapta uses she/them, Emily is a robot but she's she/her too. Is it okay if we use she/her for you too? You can touch the REM pod or the K-II if talking is too much."

There were several minutes of silence, both of them refusing to talk in case they overwhelmed the spirit. The K-II flickered but didn't quite spike, there was a soft knock, some footsteps, and then-

FWEEEEEEP! Ah, the REM pod! Entrapta waited for a moment and then the pod really began to go off.
FWEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEP

FWEEP FWEEP FWEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEP
FWEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE-

"Thank you, gosh you are doing fantastic. But hey, I need you to stop touching it if you want to answer questions and talk." Scorpia waited as the beeping lowered and slowed until the pod gave one last petulant beep to continue. "Tell you what, for any yes/no questions feel free to touch the REM pod for them. Once for yes and twice for no, do you understand?"

FWEEEP

"You are ***very*** active, the owners said the activity up here really picked up recently. Is that because of you?" Entrapta asked, finally placing the K-II down where they'd see the lights but not have it triggered elsewhere.

FWEEP

Oh this was just always so exciting!!

"So you're new here? Are there more of you?" Entrapta winced at Scorpia's slightly exasperated look. Whoops. Somehow even after years of doing this she forgot about not asking multiple questions. It was just too easy to forget when things this interesting were happening!

FWEEP...FWEEP FWEEP

She could feel her eyes sparkle with delight. Yes, she's new. No, there's no one else. Most spirits couldn't answer two questions. "You are just fascinating, thank you!"

But there was no laugh. Just a small, soft lament. *Alone.*

"Are you always this active, or are you acting out because you're alone?" Scorpia asked, clearly unsure what the answer meant. Her roaming gaze snapped to the spirit box as a hiss came through. "Hey now, none of that. If you start hissing and growling at us we'll turn this all off and leave until you've cooled down. We don't tolerate abuse and for our safety we don't deal with demons. If you don't want to answer the question, you don't have to."

Entrapta grumbled, "I wanna deal with demons."

Scorpia laughed nervously, "No, you really don't, remember Perfuma's whole thing?"

Well, when you're right, you're right. Entrapta pouted, "Unwillingly, yes."

There was another crazed laugh, a loud bang, and almost immediately afterwards an answer so faint she almost missed it.

I don't know.

"You don't know? About if this is regular for you?" FWEEP. Scorpia hummed thoughtfully for a moment before asking, "Are you new...at this?"

FWEEP

"Oooooh, when did you die? How did it happen? Do you remember traveling here? Have you-"

"Entrapta."

"What? ...ohhhh, sorry."

I don't know , the voice lamented, sounding close to tears before there was a particularly loud pop.

"Thanks okay, we can try to help you figure it out if you want. But we would need at least your name or some information about you. Are you-"

Cat- there was a popping crackling sound and then *-trah* .

"Cat..trah, oh, Catra! Hi Catra, nice to meet you! Are you trapped in this space or tied to something in here? You can touch the pod, once for here and twice for an object."

FWEEPFWEEP Another whisper, even softer this time as it rasped, *Riiiing*

"A ring?" Entrapta confirmed, looking around with some despair. The house was filled with estate and auction items, garage sale treasures and thrift store finds. The owner had contacted them last time about the boy in his ball, and as soon as this haunting started up they called again with a list of everything they'd bought recently. Apparently thrilled with their services and more

desperate to rid himself of the stomping wailing spirit in the attic. It didn't include a ring.

Hidden (Pocket)!

Entrapta quickly got up and moved to the rack of clothes they'd had pulled from the list, dragged a box over to stand on, and began to root around searching through each one's pockets.

"Do you want us to take you with-" FWEEP, Scorpia nodded along, "Sure thing Catra, we can do that. Anything else you remember?"

The silence dragged on for a while, Entrapta did her best to not blurt out any questions that would confuse their newest friend. Almost as soon as her finger touched something cool and hard there was an answer.

Adorab- the silence

"A door? Or- or Arab?" Scopira half muttered to herself only for the pod to beep at them twice. "Sorry, can you say it-"

Adu- rrahhhh

"Like Adorable?" Scorpia flinched when the pod gave two terse beeps. "Sorry, I'm not trying to be rude, I'm just not sure what you're saying."

There was another hiss, cut off by the loudest and clearest capture of the night. *SHE'S ADORA!*

"That's warning number two on the hissing, do it again and I'm turning this off." Scorpia tapped on their box, continuing in a much gentler tone, "I know this is frustrating but don't take it out of us. And I got you this time, a woman named Adora."

Entrapta studied the ring in her fingers, the weak lighting in the attic barely letting her view it at all. It was a little smaller than average (a size 4 or 5 perhaps?) dark, maybe a burnt titanium, with what looked like a stylized M in the middle. The outer legs

were both curved inwards with little serifs and in the points at the top were two tiny divots. Huh. She pulled out her mini flashlight and clicked it on. Oh! Not an M! Something else. A symbol? Hmmmm. Into the silence Entrapta asked, "What's this mean?"

"You found her!" Scorpia cheered, standing to look at the ring as well. "Aww, you had such delicate little fingers!"

Shhhhut up!

"You shush yourself, it's cute! Not at all like these meaty girls, huh? You know?" Scorpia wiggled her fingers for reference. Everything about Scorpia was larger than average due to her near-gigantism. Seven foot was no joke unless it was due to Entrapta standing next to her, simply because of her proportionate dwarfism. She had been assured that it was something rather comical to behold although she wasn't sure she'd agree with the assessment. But even on her fingers this ring was far too small. Almost a child's ring really, perhaps they were an adolescent?

"Does this mean something or is it just the letter M?" Entrapta tried again.

The box barely sounded above the static. *Promise.*

"Promise...like a promise ring?" Scorpia asked.

Fweep, the REM pod weakly beeped.

"Ah, sorry, you're probably getting tired, huh? Last question and then you can rest up for a bit, okay? Do you want us to take you with us?" Scorpia strained to listen, but Entrapta noticed the small yellow lights from the dresser.

"K-II, small spike."

"Sorry, I know it's hard, can you touch the REM pod again or make the K-II spike further just to confirm you want us to take you with us?"

The meter spiked in yellow again, flickered to the maximum of green, and went out. It was a fair attempt at least.

“Alright, thank you. You don’t need to worry about responding anymore, we’ll get you some batteries back at the hotel. I know you said you were alone, but just in case I like to close things out for everyone else.” Scorpia knocked three more times on a wood stud and Entrapta belatedly knocked on the clothing rack. “Goodbye everyone else who may be here, and thanks for having us! Alright, let’s wrap up.”

Emily continued to roll, Entrapta was not making the mistake of having the camera turn off until they left the premise again. She lost the opportunity to record a rock getting thrown and wasn’t gonna risk it a second time! No, she’d review the feeds later, from their regular camera, then thermal, then infrared, and finally full spectrum. Just in case Catra had made a physical appearance. She mindlessly helped Scorpia pack up their gear, but wasn’t too concerned. They’d gotten activity so quick she hadn’t even unpacked most of their tools.

She was still going to get her readings, log their findings, and add it all into her files and spreadsheets. Sure, they didn’t profit from exploiting the dead and otherworldly the way many “ghost hunters” did, but Entrapta still planned to release a thorough documentation of their findings once her own death had passed. Sharing information was an important part of the scientific process, but giving each spirit their own time to grieve and be forgotten was a mercy. Also, if she became a ghost then someone would know how to reach her!

She almost buzzed with excitement. Gosh she hoped she’d get the chance to inhabit Emily!

“You ready Trap?" Scorpia had already shouldered their backpack and was holding their kit in the other hand. Emily began teetering towards the entrance, following the rest of the equipment as she was programmed to, and Entrapta slipped Catra’s ring into her

overall pockets. Curiously it had stayed cool to the touch despite how long she'd been holding it. One more thing to note!

"Yup!" She had to scurry a bit to keep up even with Scorpia taking the smallest steps, but they'd long since perfected their combined walking speed.

The drive to the hotel was quick and quiet, Scorpia using the time to relax and decompress after having her sixth sense so heavily in use, and Entrapta wrote the owner with their findings and that they took the ring. It gave all of them, spirits or not, a chance to get their heads on straight. She rocked back and forth in the bucket seat as the yellow-orange light from the passing street lights washed over her in soothing waves.

Their routine at the hotel was standard as always. She hauled Emily up to the room (she was made from ultra lightweight materials and able to fold up for a good reason after all) so Scorpia could concentrate on carrying their bags without fear of her knees giving out. Once Entrapta ensured Emily and their gear was plugged in to charge while Scorpia left to shower, she quickly set out a few flashlights and placed the ring next to them.

"Here you go, feel free to use them up and please leave our battery packs and phones alone. Little hard for us to navigate without them. Okay- GOOD NIGHT!" Despite her words they stayed up working silently together for another hour, it was only after the rest of the lights went out that Catra appeared to take her up on the offer.

She eagerly stayed awake watching the flashlights go out one by one, and logged her findings with a contained squeal before passing out instantly.

All in all, a very successful evening!

Planning and Short End Scene

Chapter Summary

Planning info and a short end scene I started.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

SPT road trip, they learn more about Catra.

Catra was a young adult when she died, but she had lived a really restricted and "sheltered" life. It's clear that she was abused and it sounded cult like, but Catra is adamant it wasn't. As they travel and research trying to find "Adora", they all grow a little closer.

Eventually they narrow it down to an industrial town, and find an older newspaper article that claimed a young woman appeared to have driven her car off a cliff. Catra goes a little berserk and when she calms down she communicates that she remembers now.

Scorpia plays host body and Catra sketches things out. The car yes, but a shadowy figure and a gun. Catra was shot execution style by the woman who raised her, apparently the issue being over money but not either of theirs.

[NOT FOR THE FIC, KEEP VAGUE: Weaver knew Adora came into money although she'd also just finished her emancipation process, so Weaver couldn't access it. Catra was still technically Weaver's ward and started getting harassed to steal some of it or convince Adora to pay Weaver back for everything she did for them/gave them. Eventually Catra really lashes out and Weaver decides that's it. She offers to take Catra with her on a day trip a while afterwards, and Catra rarely has gotten to leave her home town so she agrees. Things seem good, like weirdly good. Catra is paranoid but trying to relax and enjoy the nicest time she's ever had with her foster mom. Then Weaver pulls them over on a rough section of road and the alarm bells ring again, especially as

an SUV that had been their road buddy pulls up after them. Weaver once again demands Catra help and she refuses, they end up leaving the car because Catra decides she'd rather hitch hike home and it ends up in a scuffle. The man in the SUV steps out with a pistol and gives it to Weaver once they're separated. She's given a long rant and then, hands still up and on her knees, Weaver shoots her. They stage the scene and use a rock to make the car roll into the toxic mine run off below with Catra's corpse, and then the man will call in shortly to report seeing a car go over the edge. It's too dangerous to get her body and Weaver has her stories in place about Catra, so it just gets accepted by the public.]

From this they find out more about Adora. Catra might not have "woken up" until recently but she died decades ago. Adora is now in her late sixties, and it turns out she inherited a large amount of wealth at 16 which she used to improve foster care in the local area. She fell in with a financially well to do crowd and has still been set financially her whole life. They go to visit the park that was once a run down convenience store, and where there used to be a dumpster on the broken asphalt is a statue of Catra and Adora surrounded by grass.

The statue shows both of them as teens, they're underfed and wearing worn down clothes, but they're smiling all the same as they hang off one another. The statues are a faded bronze, but Catra's ring has clearly been rubbed frequently because it shines brilliantly.

Adora never married, but about four years before someone broke into her home and stole basically everything, including Catra's old ring.

Entrapta theorizes that maybe Catra was "asleep" before because she felt safe with Adora, and when she was stolen she could sense something was wrong which caused her to "wake up".

They go to Adora's new place of residence, a senior citizen apartment complex for independent living. It's not that Adora is

senile or physically incapable, but she likes being able to still live alone without the fear that if something *were* to happen no one would know for far too long. She's surprised to have visitors and when she sees the ring, Adora breaks down in tears.

They tell her that's not all they have for her. Entrapta gives her a USB with all the evidence they recorded of Catra over the year they've spent together while Scorpia sets up the spirit box and some spare flashlights for Catra to drain.

Hey- Adora!

Entrapta smiled as their host stopped dead in her tracks. Slowly turning to stare at the spirit box she'd just been getting pissed over, Adora's voice shook, "What?"

Laughter, sweet and squeaky. Catra's real laugh, not the ones she'd been forced to borrow. Much like she'd found her true voice again, it was nice that she'd found her true laugh too. *Idiot.* So fond, so soft.

Adora blinked rapidly, chuckling wetly in confusion now as she looked between the box and them. "W-what is this?"

"This is our spirit box, it lets spirits communicate with us and Catra is very proficient at it." Scorpia explained and snorted when she was almost cut off. *Duh!* "We know Wildcat, just answering a question!"

How does- it feel? To be or- the world's- slowest- person?

It was a few different radio voices, but strung together in that very clearly Catra manner that Entrapta knew there was no one else here. She was about to explain it to Adora when the woman began to cackle.

"That's what you have to say!? Ghosts are real and you're really here- and that's what you want to tell me????" Adora slowly all but collapsed into one of her kitchen chairs as she wiped her tears

away. “It feels terrible, never grow old Catra. It sucks. Even with the knee replacement it still sucks.”

Catra laughed again, a deeper booming man’s voice but still her. *Never fear!*

“Easy for you to say!” Adora snorted, even as she continued to cry. Staring at the box like it held every secret in the world. And then she broke down. “I- I’m sorry. Catra, I’m so sorry!”

It’s okay.

[Sweet ending sequence, spt agrees to keep meeting up? Adora passes eventually and the ring goes to E/S along with anything else they’d like. It’s Scorpia who suggests maybe Adora will try to haunt something too, and Entrapta finds a letter opener shaped like a sword that has some odd readings too. Neither object ever speaks again, but they make sure the two are never separated again.]

Chapter End Notes

> I also debated having it not be so convoluted with Catra's death and instead Weaver killed her on accident but tried to make it look like she ran away and was later caught. I was never totally sure which way I wanted to go tho.
>
> Big RIP to the SPT road trip where Catra learned to ghost.

Accidentally Continued This One :)

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia and Entrapta head home with their new ward and only hit two minor complications.

Chapter Notes

> Ya know, never expected to write more for this one despite loving it, but over the last year I've fiddled enough to have an actual chapter's worth. So here you go :)

Scorpia loves what they do, she really does, but the day after was always a bit hellish for her. Her head ached and jaw popped painfully, she had odd muscle fatigue in her forearms and shins, and even her stomach sometimes turned for several hours. Entrapta theorized that when Scorpia had interactions with the supernatural that the energy used was higher than her body could make up, so it turned on itself to make up the difference. She was not sure that she fully agreed with their estimation, but it made sense.

Today was no different, despite not having to use her body as a vessel Scorpia was just tired and beaten up. She laid in bed staring at the wall half napping for at least an hour before Entrapta finally poked her awake to force the morning routine.

On the countertop was the room’s coffee pot filled and hot with all the cream and sugar packets stacked into neat little piles. Entrapta had already gone and brought back two egg and sausage burrito halves, some yogurts, and random fruit pieces from the lobby and her glass of apple juice was half gone. They’re already staring at her with a vibrating sort of energy that not even Scorpia can comprehend at this point in the day.

But she *does* know what Entrapta wants to ask.

“Sure, I don’t use the regular ones anyways.”

Entrapta clapped her hands and grabbed the four sugar packets, opening and scattering one (Scorpia winced, that just meant Entrapta intended to eat the other three in the car) on top of the desk before putting Catra's ring in the middle of the sugar circle. "Not everyone can move physical objects, but you're welcome to write or draw in the sugar if you'd like!"

Scorpia gave a lopsided smile as she poured her first cup of coffee. It's true, most spirits they encounter couldn't move anything and something as fine as sugar is often more difficult to interact with on purpose. Entrapta was either testing their new very active ward or was hoping to get a partial handprint from an accidental interaction.

After all, while the internet may have mocked the picture of a perfect shoe print they got three years back, the two of them have a framed copy at home.

Breakfast passed in relative peace beyond Entrapta literally running to and from the bathroom a few times to make sure she "didn't miss anything". Emily was closed and charging but Scorpia was watching to the best of her limited abilities.

With some food, caffeine of dubious quality, and a combination of motrin and tylenol in her system, Scorpia felt a little more like her usual self as she carefully took a quick shower. She had to hunch over a bit to not hit the ceiling and it was easier to kneel in the bathtub to wash her hair, but the semi-warm water washed the last of the morning funk away. And with that came clarity.

Gosh, she hoped that Catra wasn't feeling overwhelmed by all the energy floating around now.

It was barely 6:30, but people were waking up. Catra went from being asleep to awake and mostly alone to being with twice as many people and fed several batteries to now being surrounded by people and electronics. Scorpia didn't rush any of her morning prayers or anointments, she really couldn't if she wanted to stay healthy and sane by the end of this, but she did feel bad for how

long it's taken her when she came out and can feel Catra's bubbling frustration and fear.

"Ready Trapta?" Scorpia could already tell they are, it's more for Catra's sake really.

Entrapta quickly swept the sugar into the garbage and pocketed the ring, rushing to grab Emily as she nodded. "Absolutely! Catra, we're going to head back to our home with you and then we can start researching there. I'll pull out a few tools on the road so you can communicate a bit, but if you get tired please don't drain anything else. It would be very inconvenient!"

Scorpia chuckled as she got their bags sorted. That was an understatement. They once found a man who was trapped in an amethyst crystal, and it had just been an unfortunate echo chamber for energy consumption. He hadn't meant to, in fact he hadn't even realized he had so much energy because he was draining the SUV's battery which left them stranded for hours waiting on a tow truck. Considering he was the last time they had such an active and focused spirit… well, the caution was warranted.

It took a little extra time for Entrapta to get the driver's side readjusted for her stature, but they were still rolling on the road just before 7:30 and Scorpia dutifully picked up the K-II that Entrapta had pulled out for the first bit of the drive.

"Are you up for some questions while we drive? Remember once for yes, twice for no." Scorpia had the device resting on her knee, she knew Entrapta had protected their gear in some manner from interference but a car ride certainly wasn't ideal on the electronics side of things.

It took a minute but the meter finally peaked.

"K-II spike." Scorpia reported, and Entrapta wiggled in the driver's seat. "Wonderful, thank you! First of all, just- thank you for

trusting us, we'll do our best to get you back to Adora. Do you remember where she lives?"

Entrapta took a breath and snapped their mouth shut, and Scorpia breathed a sigh of relief. Sometimes spirits were confused by the passage of time and the person they wanted to go to was also long dead. It was easier to go in "expecting" they were alive for everyone involved.

Two orange spikes. "No. That's okay. Do you remember where you lived?" Scorpia frowned with concern as another two orange spikes flashed, her back was tensing up as Catra was beginning to realize how little she knew. Whoo boy, this could be a rough one. "No, but that's okay. That doesn't mean we're out of options, but I'm sure it's scary to not remember." The dread flashed into anger back in dread. Hmmm.

"Do you know your last name?" An orange spike then green spike. "Can you repeat that answer? That was kind of a half way between-" Red spike. "Once for yes you know, twice for sort of know." Double orange. "You kind of remember, but aren't sure?" Yellow. "Yes, that's okay if you're worried by that."

"Or embarrassed!" Entrapta chimed in, almost melting with relief a little as they did. Entrapta was willing to drive them back so Scorpia could keep recovering, but they didn't prefer it by any means. "I know I get embarrassed when I forget things, but it's just a natural part of how our brains work."

Ouch. Catra was definitely embarrassed but she was also very touchy about it. The feelings around it were murky at best.

"Catra, is it okay if I carry you for a bit?" Scorpia waited until the K-II flashed yellow. "It'll make it a bit easier for me to communicate with you, you don't have to if you'd prefer to stay with Entrapta."

She waited patiently as the minutes ticked by. Scorpia had a lot of experience with people making choices on her behalf or physically

touching and moving her around without asking. Catra might only be possessing or attached to the ring, but for now it was basically her body. Besides, it might help her feel a bit more in control to have a say in it.

The K-II flashed twice. "No? That's alright, you can stay there then."

"Scorpia's a really nice person, as I'm sure you noticed. Her holding the ring might help her read your emotions better and-"

The K-II beeped as it went all the way up and Scorpia winced as her head throbbed in pain. It was one part the loud noise and one part the anger. "Wow, you have got some capital O Opinions!" She half hissed between her teeth and turned the K-II off. "Sorry, that is a lot and it's hurting me- hang on, I just need to- one second!"

Scorpia fumbled for her water bottle for a little relief and to wait Catra out.

It did not seem to make much difference.

"I'm sorry, did we not explain that?" Entrapta asked, changing into the furthest left lane to really lean on the gas and get some nerves out most likely. Speed limits were more a suggestion to her at the end of the day. "Scorpia is sensitive to the supernatural, the veil is **super** thin for her, so she can often feel whatever you're feeling if it's a big enough emotion. She's not a mind reader or anything like that."

The anger cooled but didn't abate, still, when Scorpia turned the K-II on again it didn't shriek at her. "Do you still want to answer some questions?"

Two loud beeps, and another sustained one. "Okay, you don't have to be rude to me to say no. I get that you're angry, but I don't exactly control it."

"Yeah, she's a real fire cracker." Entrapta said, clearly quoting something or someone, but Scorpia wasn't sure who. "Put out the

cat ball? Catra, if you want to talk with us later on, just light up the cat ball okay? Okay!”

Scorpia shook it to make sure it was working before carefully slotting it into Entrapta’s modified cell phone holder. It was essentially now a gyroscope so it shouldn’t set off just from a bump in the road or the SUV moving.

Not even 8:00 and they had another ten hours to go. This could be a very difficult case if Catra was going to get this defensive the whole time.

With a sigh, Scorpia tried to wiggle in her seat to be more comfortable. It was already kicked all the way back and leaned most of the way down, but their equipment unfortunately got in the way. At this point she just wanted to go back to sleep and hopefully wake up to Catra having settled into at least a more sullen mood just for the relief it would bring. She did her best to make it come true, but it was rather thwarted by all of Catra’s drifting feelings. Of course it didn’t help that with her eyes closed came images against her eyelids. Usually in bright primary colors, Catra’s were no different in red.

A young woman, or an older girl? Hard to tell, not enough details.

A dumpster. An older woman’s evil smile. A cat. A tree. A gun.

A gun, well, shoot.

“Hey,” Scorpia croaked, blinking herself back and shocked to find several hours had passed in the few minutes she was sure she’d tried to rest.

Entrapta pointed at the passenger door, “Water first, then you can tell me what you saw!”

Scorpia drank happily and chuckled, “They always know when someone shares with me, and I understand you most likely were not trying to share so I do apologize for that. Again, I can’t really stop it from happening.”

Catra’s presence shivered, that was the only way to explain it, and then the radio which had been softly fuzzing with white noise crackled, *Ok.* Ooooookay, VERY active! Scorpia glanced at the dashboard but didn’t see a low battery warning, which was great and terrifying. She could feel a headache just from imagining leaving the spirit box up all the time. Maybe she needed to bust out the ovilus? Focus.

“You said you didn’t remember how you died, which is fine. Was it a violent death, do you think?”

A pause, cold, denial. The cat ball lit up.

“Why do you think that?” Entrapta asked before immediately shrinking in the driver's seat. “Sorry, sorry, ignore me, I can ask later!”

A small curl of amusement, but cut out by dread.

“Okay. Please understand I’m trying to narrow options here and not claiming anything.” A gun, but also a tree. “Do you think you killed yourself?”

“Cat ball,” Entrapta whispered.

“Please, Entrapta, please watch the road!” Scorpia then noticed the phone in her hand and grabbed it. “And no cell phone in hand when driving, I can film!”

“Cat ball again, and I am watching the road, it is very empty at the moment!”

Scorpia huffed, but any rebuke about the cars she could literally see through the windows and mirrors was forgotten as the hair on her body lifted. “Sorry, Catra, making sure we don’t join you too quickly! Okay, didn’t kill yourself. Could you have been murdered?”

Silence. Too silent. Too still. Too cold. The cat ball lit up once. Scorpia held her breath. Denial, fear, shame. And a second time.

Sometimes that's how it worked. Spirits who had been killed in life would feel like it was their fault, or they deserved it. Not often, but often enough. And Catra had been young. Most likely it was someone she knew, someone who was supposed to care for her. Of course she probably didn't actually remember the event itself, at least not yet. Scorpia had a sneaking suspicion of what would happen to their radio if Catra had remembered.

The growling.

Entrapta had no less to worry about when it came to demons, but it was very easy to not be afraid of them when you couldn't feel their presence. Scorpia hadn't feared them until Perfuma had called them at her wits end with a new property she was trying to sell. Nasty business all around, and she preferred to stay far, far away after that. The problem was that no one knew what demons really were. Sure, they used the name demon for it, the easiest way to talk about them, but that didn't mean christianity held the answers by any means. They had once theorized on what that thing could have come from in Perfuma's basement, and the only conclusion anyone reached was that someone had died there violently. Maybe it was a spirit gone mad from rage and isolation. Maybe it just needed a push. And considering how big Catra's emotions were, Scorpia had no desire to learn more on that.

"Okay, we'll keep thinking on it then." Scorpia smiled at the cat ball and stopped recording. On the notes app, she quickly typed: lying, scared, gun.

Entrapta took her phone back, and glanced at the screen before tucking it in her pocket. Once away she patted her shirt pocket softly. "It's okay, we can figure this out together! Let's just take our time, but if there are other questions you're willing-to-answer-Iwouldrealyliketoaskmorequestions!"

"Did you already eat one of the sugar packets?" Scorpia asked feeling a bit breathless from the speed of the question.

“No.” Entrapta said at the same time the cat ball lit up once. After a minute it was clearly not going to go off again and she muttered, “Narc.”

“...how many sugar packets did you have?”

“Two. And a red bull. Don’t worry about it!” Their answer would have already put Scorpia on edge but that was only underlined as they flew into the passing lane to over take two semi-trucks.

Scorpia immediately tuned the radio looking for a classical station, and as she jumped from station to station, she could hear that squeaky laugh again. “Listen here buster brown, you’re already dead! I’m trying to stay alive for a while longer!” The radio continued to fade in and out along with *that’s a- fine.* “Appreciate the understanding, thanks.”

Entrapta pouted but allowed Scorpia to take the empty and chuck it into the back foot well without much complaint. With Entrapta beyond fueled up, Scorpia more alert, and Catra apparently appeased at her discomfort the rest of the drive was almost pleasant.

End Notes

This one I've clung to desperately because the whole first chapter is done! Like! C'mon brain, chugga chugga woo woo baby! But alas, the train crashed at the station, so here it goes.

Ch2 is the fic plot/outline.

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